THE SAFFRON CHURN

HOW THE BJP AND THE SANGH PARIVAR ARE TRYING TO REINVENT THEMSELVES AFTER THE SUBPAR PERFORMANCE IN THE LOK SABHA ELECTION

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Photograph by **BANDEEP SINGH**

ON **September 2, as the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS)** wrapped up its Akhil Bharatiya Samanvay Baithak, the three-day national coordination meeting of affiliate organisations, *prachar pramukh* Sunil Ambekar's press conference was buzzing with reporters. And he didn't disappoint, picking the opportunity to, as one participant put it, "drop a couple of bombs". For one, he clarified that the Sangh was in favour of the contentious national caste census (with riders, of course) and, two, he made a public admission of unresolved "issues" between the RSS and its ideological offspring, the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP), which rules at the Centre.

Ambekar did clarify that it was a "family matter" which would be smoothened out through "discussions". But then he had already said enough to make the headlines the next day. The caste census, meant to bring equality of representation and opportunities to those on society's margins, has been a key demand of the Opposition, which the ruling party has in the past described as an attempt to "divide Hindu society". As for the 'family matter', BJP spokespersons went into no-comment mode, as did party president J.P. Nadda who had attended the *baithak* of the 40-odd Sangh affiliates in Palakkad, Kerala.